priority was arguing its case well, he said, adding, "We have strong grounds." Not to be outdone, the Karnataka CM also spoke of providing freedom fighter pensions across the border and funds for Kannada-medium schools there—for there also exist notable Kannada-speaking areas in Maharashtra. Bommai has also appointed a new chairman to the Karnataka Border and River Protection Commission (a position that had been lying vacant) and proposed an all party-meeting on his side of the fence to discuss the issue.

Belagavi is a difficult leftover from the days when India decided the best way to create its states was on the basis of language. The new Mysore state—before it was renamed Karnataka in 1973—was formed in 1956 by amalgamating districts that were earlier governed by the Nizam's state of Hyderabad and the directly British-ruled Madras and Bombay presidencies. In that process, the districts of Belgaum (except for Chandgad taluk), Bijapur, Dharwar and Kanara were transferred to the new state from Bombay. But with boundary disputes persisting between Maharashtra, Karnataka and Kerala, the Centre constituted a one-man commission with Meherchand Mahajan, a former chief justice of India, in October 1966, to resolve the issue.

Mahajan's report, which came in August 1967, recommended that 264 villages be transferred from Mysore to Maharashtra and 247 villages from the Maratha side back to the southern state. So towns such as Nippani, Khanapur and Nandgad were to go to Maharashtra while Mysore was to get the talukas of South Solapur, Akkalkot and Jat. As for Belgaum city, crucially, he recommended that it stay with Karnataka. An aggrieved Maharashtra demanded that the report be rejected outright while Karnataka called for its implementation in toto. The issue has festered ever since, flaring up notably in 1986 with border agitations that claimed nine lives.

Belagavi is an agricultural district known for its 24 sugar factories, besides being a hub of foundries. With its sizeable Marathi population, Belagavi city itself—located almost exactly halfway between Bengaluru and Mumbai—had been a base for the political outfit Maharashtra Ekikaran Samiti (MES). Formed in 1948 with the agenda of uniting Marathi-speaking regions, the MES used to win assembly seats in the region and controlled the Belagavi City Corporation through the 1980s, even passing council resolutions for a merger with Maharashtra. In 2005, when an MES-led city council passed such a resolution, the city mayor Vijay More was manhandled by Kannada activists in Bengaluru who blackened his face with ink. A year ago, Kannada activists similarly smeared black ink on another MES leader, Deepak Dalvi, for leading a protest against the Karnataka legislature's winter session being held in Belagavi.

The Belagavi sessions were a fallout of the dispute. In 2004, Maharashtra, whose main demand is that a region encompassing 865 villages and Belagavi city be handed over to it, filed a lawsuit in the Supreme Court. Karnataka responded by announcing Belagavi as its second capital. From 2006, the city hosted the legislature sessions in December. Even a second state secretariat—a replica of Bengaluru's Vidhana Soudha—was built there. In 2014, the Centre cleared a long-pending proposal to formalise the Kannada names of Karnataka's cities. Bangalore became Bengaluru, Mysore became Mysuru...and Belgaum became Belagavi. The last one has never sat well with Maharashtra.

From those crescendos, the issue had quietened over the past decade. Since the 1990s, the MES has been losing ground in Belagavi city to the BJP and Congress, says Ashok Chandargi, president of the Belagavi District Kannada Organisations Action Committee. "It is an emotional issue but people see through the political agendas," he says. "We have always insisted that the public should not be made to suffer due to the border issue."

In December 2019, Uddhav Thackeray, then newly become Maharashtra CM, triggered a war of words with his pledge to unite 'Karnataka-occupied' Marathi-speaking regions. For the Shiv Sena, which has backed the MES in elections, the border issue is closely linked to the party's core plank of Marathi



"NO VILLAGE IN MAHARASHTRA WILL GO TO KARNATAKA! THE STATE WILL FIGHT IN THE SC TO GET MARATHI-SPEAKING AREAS INCLUDING BELGAUM, KARWAR, NIPPANI"

DEVENDRA FADNAVIS
Maharashtra Dy CM



"@BJP4KARNATAKA SHOULD WAKE UP AND CALL FOR AN ALL-PARTY MEETING TO DISCUSS THE WAY FORWARD"

SIDDARAMAIAH
Ex-CM, Karnataka (Congress)



"IF KARNATAKA IS READY TO LEAVE BELGAUM, KARWAR AND NIPPANI, THEN WE CAN DISCUSS WHAT CAN BE GIVEN TO THEM"

SHARAD PAWAR
NCP chief